

**The Anxiety Trade-off: A Qualitative Study of Term-time Internships among
CUHKSZ Senior Students**

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ENG2001 English for Academic Purposes II

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December 12, 2025

Abstract

Term-time internships have become a critical employability strategy in Asian universities, yet the psychological implications for senior students remain underexplored. To address this gap, this qualitative study investigates the lived experiences of senior undergraduates at The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen (CUHKSZ). Drawing on in-depth semi-structured interviews and thematic analysis, the research explores how seniors perceive the interplay between internship demands, academic pressure, and personal well-being. Findings reveal a distinct "anxiety trade-off": students consciously accept physiological fatigue and reduced academic focus to mitigate career anxiety. Contrary to expectations, internships served as a remedy for the "fear of idleness" and a source of self-efficacy, with physiological costs (e.g., sleep deprivation) mediated primarily by environmental conflicts rather than workload intensity. Challenging Western narratives where employment is driven by financial necessity, this study concludes that CUHKSZ seniors view internships as a "strategic investment" in self-efficacy. These findings suggest that universities should address structural stress sources to better support the psychological needs of students transitioning from school to work.

The Anxiety Trade-off: A Qualitative Study of Term-time Internships among CUHKSZ Senior Students

Term-time internships have become an increasingly prevalent strategy for senior students in Asian universities to enhance employability. While extensive research has examined the work-study dynamic, results remain contested; predominant Western literature suggests that term-time employment often competes with academic attainment and physiological well-being (Callender, 2008; Hall, 2010; Carney et al., 2005), yet others argue that work undertaken specifically for "career-specific skills" can actually enhance professional self-efficacy (Wenz & Yu, 2010; Broadbridge & Swanson, 2005). However, these studies frequently overlook the distinct psychological landscape of high-pressure Asian academic environments, where intense expectations and conditional support create unique stressors (Nguyen et al., 2024). Furthermore, few studies isolate the lived experiences of senior students, for whom the "fear of idleness" often outweighs traditional academic pressure. To address these gaps, this qualitative study investigates the experiences of senior undergraduates at CUHKSZ. By exploring the interplay between academic and career anxiety, sleep quality, and time management, this research aims to uncover the strategic "anxiety trade-off" mechanism that seniors employ to navigate the transition from university to the labor market.

Literature review

Extensive research has examined the complex relationship between term-time employment and university life, often viewing it as a competition for limited time and energy. A predominant body of literature suggests that working during the semester creates significant academic and psychological costs. Callender (2008) provided robust

evidence from UK universities, demonstrating that term-time working has a measurable detrimental effect on final year marks and the probability of achieving a "good degree". Beyond academic metrics, the physiological toll is evident; Carney, McNeish, and McColl (2005) found that working students reported mental and physical health levels significantly poorer than general population norms. Furthermore, Hall (2010) highlighted that as work hours increase, students are often forced to trade off essential leisure and study time, leading to heightened fatigue and a decrease in overall quality of life.

However, outcomes are not uniformly negative. Broadbridge and Swanson (2005) argued that impacts depend on students' individual appraisal of role conflicts. Crucially, Wenz and Yu (2010) found that while general employment may lower grades, work undertaken to acquire "career-specific skills" was associated with higher academic performance. This suggests that internships—structured and career-aligned—may function differently than the low-skilled casual jobs often cited in literature.

Despite these insights, two significant research gaps remain. First, there is a marked geographical and cultural gap. Most existing studies are situated in Western contexts, such as the UK, Australia, and the US, where cultural norms and pressure intensity differ significantly from Asian contexts. As Nguyen et al. (2024) noted, cultural factors in Asian contexts, such as conditional parental support and intense academic expectations, create a distinct psychological landscape for working students. Second, a conceptual gap persists regarding the type of employment. Most previous research aggregates all "term-time employment," predominantly focusing on low-skilled service roles like catering or retail. Few studies isolate the psychological impact of internships used strategically to mitigate "Career Anxiety."

To address these gaps, this qualitative study explores the lived experiences of senior students at CUHKSZ, specifically focusing on three dimensions which are identified in the literature as critical to the work-study dynamic. First, sleep quality is examined as a primary indicator of physiological cost, given consistent findings linking work hours to fatigue and sleep deprivation. Second, self-efficacy is investigated as a potential psychological gain, as career-related work has been shown to bolster professional identity. Finally, time management is explored as the essential coping mechanism that students are forced to develop to balance dual roles. Thus, the study seeks to answer:

How do CUHKSZ senior students perceive the impact of term-time internships on their academic and career anxiety, and in what ways do they navigate the interaction between these experiences and their sleep quality, self-efficacy, and time management skills?

Method

Participants

This study employed purposive sampling to select participants who could provide rich insights into the phenomenon of term-time internships. The selection criteria were strictly defined: participants must be (1) senior undergraduate students (Year 4) at CUHKSZ, and (2) currently undertaking a term-time internship alongside their coursework.

A total of four senior students (Ocean, Focus, Bobby, and Lyne) were selected for in-depth semi-structured interviews. To ensure the findings captured a breadth of experiences within the high-pressure academic environment, participants were recruited

from diverse disciplines, including Financial Engineering, Computer Science, Translation, and Finance. Despite their different academic backgrounds, all participants shared the common characteristic of facing imminent labor market entry. Table 1 presents the demographic profile of the interviewees.

Table 1

Information of the Interviewees

Name	Gender	Major
Ocean	Female	Finance
Focus	Female	Translation
Bobby	Male	Computer Science
Lyne	Female	Financial Engineering

Results

Based on the thematic analysis of semi-structured interviews with four senior students, the findings revealed a complex psychological dynamic unique to the graduation transition phase. The analysis identified a distinct "anxiety trade-off": participants reported that term-time internships significantly alleviated their career anxiety. Unlike lower-year students who struggled with coursework conflicts, seniors perceived internships as a necessary remedy for the "anxiety of idleness" rather than a source of academic stress.

The Anxiety Shift: From GPA Preservation to "Fear of Idleness"

Contrary to the anticipation that internships would heighten academic anxiety, participants universally reported that term-time internships alleviated their overall anxiety. This was attributed by participants to two factors: the diminishing importance of GPA and the burden of unstructured time.

As seniors, most participants had already completed major graduation requirements. Consequently, the "academic anxiety" related to grades was minimal.

Ocean (Finance) articulated this shift explicitly:

If I spent all my time on study, I would be anxious because the result (higher GPA) is not what I value anymore. [Instead], doing an internship makes me feel less anxious and improves my self-efficacy because I am doing something I recognize as valuable.

Furthermore, "free time" in the senior year was described not as a luxury, but as a source of panic. **Focus (Translation)** noted that the internship provided a necessary external force for discipline:

If I have too much free time this semester, I will feel uncomfortable all over. I need a job to whip and squeeze me to make me feel fulfilled... I cannot handle pure leisure.

Thus, the data indicated that for these seniors, stress primarily stemmed from the fear of stagnation rather than coursework demands.

Physiological Cost: Structural Conflicts over Workload Intensity

Regarding sleep quality, participants reported that stress stemmed less from the work itself and more from structural conflicts between the "intern schedule" and the "university dormitory schedule." **Lyne (FE)**, who lived on campus, faced significant challenges:

The main conflict is waking up early for commuting while roommates sleep late. I can't go to bed early due to the dorm environment, so I only sleep about 6 hours... It is the environment, not the work itself, that squeezes my sleep.

Strategic Coping: Improving Time Management Skills

Regarding time management, the findings showed that the pressure of balancing work and study pushed participants to develop better planning skills. Because free time was scarce, participants learned to utilize "fragmented time." **Ocean (Finance)** described transforming her daily commute into productive study time:

I generally do [schoolwork] during commute... if I didn't use this time, it would just be wasted.

Similarly, **Lyne (FE)** highlighted an improvement in mental prioritization. Instead of relying on rigid schedules, she developed an outcome-oriented mindset:

You must optimize. I don't use a schedule, but I know exactly what needs to be done before I sleep.

In summary, contrary to expectations of heightened pressure, the results indicate that internships mitigated overall anxiety by resolving the "Fear of Idleness." Also, findings link sleep deprivation to environmental conflicts rather than workload, while students' time management skills were generally improved. Ultimately, internships function as a psychological buffer rather than a burden.

Discussion

Our findings indicate a rational "anxiety trade-off," where senior students perceive internships not as academic stressors but as strategic investments. They consciously accept compromised sleep quality and tighter time management demands to mitigate career anxiety, prioritizing practical ability over academic perfection. By replacing the abstract metric of grades with tangible work experience, they gain the self-efficacy that coursework no longer provides.

Our study yields a conclusion contrary to dominant Western literature (Callender, 2008; Hall, 2010), which posits that term-time employment heightens academic anxiety by competing with study hours. In contrast, we found that internships do not exacerbate academic anxiety for senior students. This divergence stems from a shift in value systems: as graduation nears, the marginal utility of a high GPA diminishes while the value of employability rises. Consequently, participants view internships not as distractions but as strategic remedies for "blank résumé" anxiety. This aligns with Wenz and Yu's (2010) finding that work undertaken for "career-specific skills" complements rather than substitutes education.

While traditional views argue that sacrificing leisure lowers quality of life (Broadbridge & Swanson, 2005; Hall, 2010), our study identifies a distinct "Fear of

Idleness" among high-achieving seniors. Participants perceived unstructured time not as relief, but as a source of panic regarding stagnation. By filling this void, internships serve as a psychological defense mechanism against existential anxiety. This refines Broadbridge and Swanson's (2005) "role conflict" model, suggesting that in hyper-competitive environments, "being busy" serves to mitigate rather than increase stress.

Regarding physiological health, our findings refine the view that employment inevitably harms well-being (Carney et al., 2005). We found that workload does not directly dictate sleep duration; instead, deprivation is mediated by environmental conflicts (e.g., dormitory schedule clashes) and mental tension. High-intensity roles often induce "mental hyper-arousal" that disrupts sleep quality rather than opportunity. This implies physiological costs are not a linear result of working hours (Hovdhaugen, 2015), but a structural outcome of the interaction between work, living environment, and mental state.

In summary, this study reveals a rational "anxiety trade-off" where seniors prioritize self-efficacy over academic perfection. It fills a critical gap regarding high-pressure Asian contexts (Nguyen et al., 2024) by redefining internships as a strategic cure for "idleness," challenging Western narratives of financial necessity. While limited by sample size ($N = 4$) and potential survivor bias, these findings provide vital insights into the school-to-work transition, highlighting the urgent need for universities to address the structural and environmental mediators of student well-being.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this qualitative study highlighted a "anxiety trade-off" among CUHKSZ seniors, who strategically accepted physiological fatigue to mitigate career

anxiety and the "fear of idleness." By challenging Western narratives of financial necessity, this research filled a critical gap regarding high-stakes Asian academic environments, suggesting that term-time internships served not as a negative stressor, but as a psychological buffer and a bridge to professional identity for seniors. Furthermore, the findings provided valuable practical insights for students to manage transition anxiety and for universities to optimize structural support systems. However, the study was limited by the small sample size (N=4) and potential survivor bias, which constrained the generalizability of the results to the broader student population. Future research should examine the proposed "anxiety trade-off" dynamic in larger and more diverse populations to ensure the validity and generalizability of these findings across different institutional contexts.

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Appendix A

Interview Guide

A. Background & Context (Internship Characteristics)

1. Could you briefly describe your current term-time internship?
2. Why did you choose to undertake an internship during your senior year?

B. The "Anxiety Trade-off" (Academic vs. Career)

1. How does your internship experience influence your self-efficacy regarding future employment?
2. As a senior student, how do you balance your academic anxiety (e.g., GPA, thesis) with your internship?
3. What are the main sources of stress you experience this semester?
4. Is the stress mainly coming from "too much work" or "fear of having nothing to do" (idleness)?

C. Physiological Impact (Sleep & Health)

1. How does your internship schedule affect your **sleep quality** and daily energy levels?

D. Strategic Coping (Time Management)

1. How do you cope with the time pressure from handling both study and internship?

E. Overall Reflection

1. Looking back, do you feel this term-time internship benefits your psychological **well-being** overall? Why or why not?

(Interviews will last 20–30 minutes; conducted in English or Chinese depending on participant preference. Audio-recorded with informed consent.)

Appendix B

Thematic Analysis Coding Table

Core Themes	Sub-themes / Codes	Representative Quotes (Evidence from Interviews)
1. The Anxiety Shift	Diminishing GPA Utility	I didn't plan to protect my GPA from the start... If I spent all my time on study, I would be anxious because the result (higher GPA) is not what I value anymore. (Ocean) Personally, my anxiety about going to school is because my GPA is not high... [but] the logic of learning that small internship... except for other things, you must feel confident. (Bobby)
	Fear of Idleness (Existential Anxiety)	If I have too much free time this semester, I will feel uncomfortable all over. I need a job to whip and squeeze me to make me feel fulfilled... I cannot handle pure leisure. (Focus) If I don't use this time [for internship], I might just waste it or spend it on anxious overthinking. (Ocean)
	Professional Confidence & Self-efficacy	Even if I don't reach my ideal level... I have a 'bottom line' (backup plan) with this job. This makes me feel less anxious about the future. (Ocean) If the career path is clear, internship can alleviate anxiety... You are just satisfying a standardized profile. If you satisfy it, you won't be anxious. (Lyne)
2. Physiological Cost	Sleep Quality: Environmental Conflict	I basically sleep about six hours before going to work... because of commuting, I must get up early, but my schedule conflicts with [other] university students [who sleep late]. (Lyne)

Sleep Quality: Mental Hyper-arousal Especially when you sleep... your brain is going crazy. Even if you don't turn [toss and turn], it's hard for you to go from a state of alertness to a state of relaxation. (Bobby)

Commuting Fatigue Commuting consumes mental energy... on the subway during morning rush hour, everyone looks desperate, as if their energy is sucked away. (Lyne)

3. Strategic Coping Fragmented Time Integration I generally do [schoolwork] during commute... it's just doing it conveniently. If I didn't use this time, it would just be wasted. (Ocean)

I watch content I saved in my favorites [during the commute] to pretend I am not on the subway. (Lyne)

Mental Optimization (Result-oriented) I don't use a schedule, but I know exactly what needs to be done before I sleep. (Lyne)

Efficiency Compression When I really want to do something, I can do it efficiently... There won't be any [time management] problems. (Bobby)
